

Too many designers dilute InterContinental's impact

New hotel linking channel and Greenway proves solid but forgettable

By Robert Campbell
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

"Boring" is the word for the new InterContinental Boston Hotel and Residences, the huge new twin-towered glassy mountain that recently appeared downtown.

It's hard to imagine how so much money and talent could have gone into a project so lacking in architectural interest.

This is a big building. Total cost was \$330 million. There are 424 hotel rooms on the lower 12 floors, and 130 condos on the upper eight. Many of both enjoy spectacular water views. The condos get a bonus, too: access to room service and housekeeping from the hotel.

There are also three or four bars and restaurants, depending on how you count, a health club, event rooms, and underground parking for 375 cars.

The good news is that the InterContinental is solid, thoughtful urban design. The bad news is that it's forgettable architecture.

As urban design, it stacks a variety of vital activities on a site that once was a dreary power plant. That's a huge improvement. And it possesses one great virtue: it's a pedestrian link between two of Boston's most important urban spaces.

On one side, the InterContinental overlooks the future Rose Fitzgerald Kennedy Greenway. On the other, it faces Fort Point Channel. The hotel lobby is a long, high, wide corridor, a kind of indoor street, that stretches from a door on Atlantic Avenue to another door on the water. Restaurants open off this street at the channel end, where they can spill tables out toward the water in good weather.

That valuable connection was mandated by Boston's planning agency, the Boston Redevelopment Authority. The BRA sees Fort Point Channel as one of the delights of Boston's future. It will become a lively water plaza, crisscrossed by boats and surrounded by dwellings, offices, restaurants, and cultural institutions.

The Children's Museum, directly across the channel from the InterContinental, is constructing a new wing designed by Cambridge Seven Associates. Already, at night, the view of sparkling lights on the dark channel water is beautiful.

All that big-picture design is promising. But the closer you look at the InterContinental, the less interesting it becomes.

There were several architects, which may be part of the problem. The exterior, and the floor

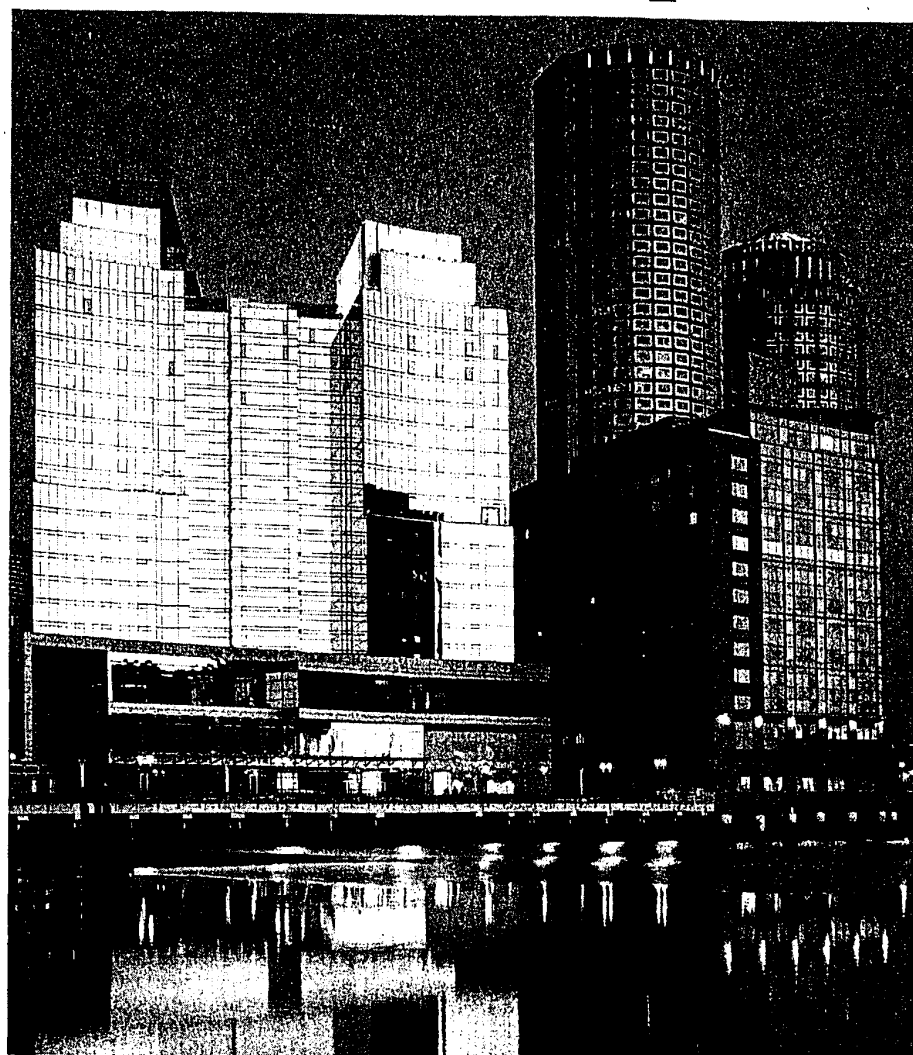
It's a building that's been sculpted in so many ways that it's lost coherence. It looks like a random pile of glass blocks. That's especially true on the downtown side.

plans of the interior, are by the firm of Elkus Manfredi of Boston. Hotel interiors are by a New York firm, Brennan Beer Gorman Monk (BBGM). Cambridge Seven is doing a restaurant that's due to open in the spring, which will be called the "Sushi-Teq." The name is a hands-across-the-sea gesture at globalization: the Sushi-Teq will (somehow) marry the world of sushi and that of tequila.

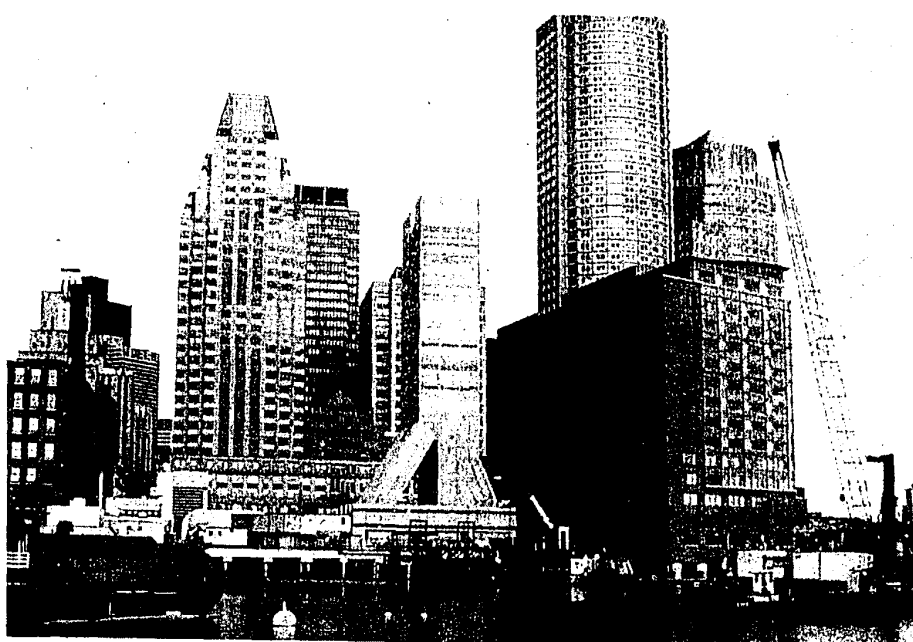
And there were other players in the design. InterContinental Hotels Group was one. Brian Fallon, a Boston developer who is a partner in Extell Development Co., which owns the site, was another. We're looking at a broth with too many cooks.

Howard Elkus is a good architect who, many years ago, designed one of Boston's best buildings, the Heritage on the Garden at Boylston and Arlington.

At InterContinental, the moves he's made sound good in Elkus's words.



ANTON GRASSL



The vent stack from the underground Central Artery (above) is hidden inside the InterContinental Boston Hotel and Residences (top), as seen from across Fort Point Channel.

The building is clad in semi-reflective glass (plus a little polished granite), he says, so that it can be a bright, alive presence on the water and the street. The choppy, curving, angled faces of the building's twin towers are shaped to maximize the best views from inside. They're also intended to remind you of sails (Elkus mentions the Tall Ships).

It sounds good, but the result is a building that's been sculpted in so many ways that it's lost coherence. It looks like a random pile of glass blocks. That's especially true on the downtown side.

What most Bostonians are likely to visit is the hotel interior and its restaurants. BBGM's design, here, looks as if it's been done by a cosmetics firm, in many shades of nude.

There are grotesque attempts in the lobby to create a domestic feeling. Bookcases contain not only books but the odd Monopoly board. There are fake fireplaces, fake trees in pots, and weird little clusters of living-room furniture that sit on rugs that look like tiny islands, lost in the big lobby. All this is supposed to say "home and hearth" but what it really says is "phony and fake."

The chief restaurant, Miel, can stand for the rest of the interior architecture. It's supposed to remind you of Provencal France, or so the menu says. It certainly

doesn't remind you of Boston.

The floor is raised so you'll get a view of the channel through an all-glass wall — and then, unbelievably, the glass is obscured with big drapes. I guess the drapes, once again, are supposed to make you feel like you're back home in Dubuque, instead of in the exciting urban center you're actually inhabiting.

Miel is furnished with cheesy pseudo-antique chairs, colors in eight shades of beige, another fake fire framed in boulders(!), and chandeliers that look as if they've been recycled from an abandoned Schrafft's.

It's hard to imagine how a first-class restaurant could be designed with so little imagination. Boston doesn't lack creative young architects — for example, those who did the Diva Lounge in Davis Square, which I recently wrote about and which is the cover, this month, of the leading national architecture magazine. Miel could use someone like that.

The InterContinental interiors are like the speech of a politician who, rather than thinking his or her own thoughts, speaks only what's been approved by handlers and focus groups. Like such a pol, the InterContinental interior is the lowest-common-denominator invention of marketing experts.

It's only fair to point out that architect Elkus faced and solved some weird problems. The site is split by a fat, multi-story concrete vent stack, which serves the underground Central Artery. The InterContinental had to be, somehow, fitted around it. That job has been done so well you're never aware of it.

But on the down side, once again, there's the landscape treatment at the waterfront. Sasaki is a good landscape firm. But its design here, mostly green grass and pink granite, feels as though any life it may once have possessed has been boiled out of it.

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